IELTS Turbo · Week 8 · Saturday · Writing and Speaking

Media and advertising

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Media and advertising: who shapes what we think? (187 words)

The **mass media** shape the way we see the world. Every day we meet hundreds of messages, and the most visible is the **advertisement**. Marketing experts study their **target audience** carefully, because a strong **brand** can **make or break** a product. To **persuade** people, firms use a famous **celebrity** to **endorse** a product, or pay an **influencer** whose followers trust their taste. **Impulse buying** is no accident: shop layouts and online offers are designed to encourage it, and the modern **consumer** is rarely a fully free chooser.

News is also under pressure. A dramatic **headline** attracts more readers than a careful report, which is why a **tabloid** often prefers the **sensational** to the accurate. Readers **fall for** stories that go **viral** before anyone checks them, and any **bias** in reporting can distort public opinion. Many people now **subscribe** to trusted newspapers or **broadcast** services that promise **credible** information.

Not everyone accepts the limits that governments sometimes place on content, and **censorship** remains controversial. Many educators therefore insist on **media literacy**: the ability to question what we see, read and hear. Without it, we risk **taking everything at face value**.

Useful phrases from the article

Phrase	Meaning
make or break	decide the success of
fall for	are tricked by
taking everything at face value	believing it without thought

The 20 new words

Word		Meaning	Example
mass media	n	TV, newspapers and the internet together	*The mass media shape public opinion.*
advertisement	n	a public message selling a product	*Advertisements for sweets target children.*
consumer	n	a person who buys goods	*Consumers want clear information.*
brand	n	a product name with a certain image	*A strong brand builds trust.*
influencer	n	a person with many followers who affects buying	*Influencers promote products on social media.*
celebrity	n	a famous person	*Celebrity endorsements increase sales.*

endorse	v	to publicly support a product	*The player endorses a sportswear brand.*
censorship	n	control of what the public can see	*Censorship limits freedom of speech.*
bias	n	an unfair preference for one side	*News reports should avoid bias.*
headline	n	the title of a news story	*The headline was misleading.*
tabloid	n	a newspaper with short, sensational stories	*Tabloids often exaggerate stories.*
broadcast	v	to send out on radio or TV	*The match was broadcast worldwide.*
subscribe	v	to pay regularly for a service	*Many people subscribe to streaming services.*
target audience	n	the group a message is aimed at	*The target audience is young adults.*
persuade	v	to make someone believe or do something	*Advertising tries to persuade us to buy.*
credible	adj	able to be trusted	*Choose credible sources of news.*
sensational	adj	designed to shock or excite	*Sensational stories sell more papers.*
viral	adj	spreading very fast online	*The video went viral in a day.*
impulse buying	n	buying without planning	*Shop displays encourage impulse buying.*
media literacy	n	the ability to judge media messages	*Media literacy should be taught in school.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

Word		Meaning
legislation	n	laws made by a government
taxation	n	the system of collecting taxes
public spending	n	money the government spends
subsidy	n	money given by the government to help an industry
welfare	n	support for people in need
inequality	n	unfair difference between groups
poverty	n	the state of being very poor
infrastructure	n	roads, railways and basic services
policy	n	a plan of action by a government
regulation	n	an official rule

Practice: fill the gaps

sensational · credible · subscribe · advertisement · consumer · headline · target audience · tabloid

1. _____ stories sell more papers.
2. Choose _____ sources of news.
3. Many people _____ to streaming services.
4. _____ for sweets target children.
5. _____ want clear information.
6. The _____ was misleading.
7. The _____ is young adults.
8. _____ often exaggerate stories.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

audience (n): the people who watch or listen
bestseller (n): a very popular book
billboard (n): a large outdoor advertising board
blog (n): a personal website with posts
clickbait (n): a headline designed to attract clicks
commercial (n): a paid advertisement on TV or radio
coverage (n): the amount of reporting on an event
documentary (n): a factual film
editorial (n): an opinion article by a newspaper
exposure (n): being seen by the public
fake news (n): false stories shown as real
feedback (n): comments about something
free press (n): media not controlled by the state
gossip (n): talk about other people's private lives
hashtag (n): a word with # used on social media
in the public eye (adj): often seen by the public
journalist (n): a person who writes news
launch (v): to start a campaign
logo (n): a symbol for a company
magazine (n): a regular publication with articles
newsletter (n): a regular email or report
paparazzi (n): photographers who follow celebrities
press release (n): a statement given to the media
propaganda (n): biased information to influence people
publicity (n): public attention
ratings (n): figures showing how many people watch
reality TV (n): shows about ordinary people
slogan (n): a short, memorable phrase
sponsor (n): a firm that pays for an event
trending (adj): very popular online now

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Advertising encourages people to buy things they do not need. To what extent do you agree or disagree?
2. Some people think the media has too much influence on young people. What are the problems and what can be done?
3. Fake news is spreading on social media. What are the causes and solutions?
4. Do the advantages of celebrity endorsement outweigh the disadvantages?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Advertising informs people about new products and supports free media.
- **Against / bad:** It creates false needs, especially in children, and pushes impulse buying.
- **For / good:** Social media lets ordinary people share news quickly.
- **Against / bad:** False stories go viral faster than corrections, and bias is hard to spot.
- **For / good:** Media literacy classes teach young people to question what they see.
- **Against / bad:** Strict censorship limits freedom and can hide the truth.

Speaking

Part 1

- How do you get the news?
- Do you read newspapers?
- Do you like advertisements?
- Which social media do you use?
- Have you ever bought something because of an advertisement?

Part 3

- Do advertisements influence what people buy?
- Should advertising to children be banned?
- Is traditional news dying?
- How can people recognize false information?

Part 2 cue card. Describe an advertisement you remember. You should say: what it was for, where you saw it, what it showed, and explain why you remember it.

Answers

1. Sensational (sensational)
2. credible (credible)
3. subscribe (subscribe)
4. Advertisements (advertisement)
5. Consumers (consumer)
6. headline (headline)
7. target audience (target audience)
8. Tabloids (tabloid)